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Gender, incarceration, and peacebuilding: A qualitative study on women inmates in Mexican prisons with a peacebuilding perspective

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Abstract

Mexico is one of the least peaceful nations in the world, and despite years of rule by governments affiliated with three distinct political parties, this situation has not changed. To comprehend this flawed system, it is important to examine the connections between gender and peacelessness, as well as the crimes committed by women, their confinement circumstances, and their chances of reintegration. There is a wealth of literature that discusses the incarceration of women, the causes of women's criminal behavior, and the conditions under which women are detained around the globe, but especially in Mexico. But there aren't enough studies that look at such issues from the standpoint of peacebuilding. A number of 33 in-depth interviews were done as part of the current qualitative research in jails spread throughout six different regions of the nation to examine these situations more thoroughly and in depth. The conclusions we found reveal the intimate connections between incarceration and structural gender-based violence. Structural gendered violence is present throughout the interviewees' lives, contributes to the

events and activities that push these women into prison, and ultimately is replicated while they are there. To put it simply, while investigating the relationship between structural gender violence and crime, we discovered that the same structural violence may be closely linked to the interviewees' potential innocence or at the very least, their self-perception of innocence. The pages that follow demonstrate how and why.

GENDER, INCARCERATION, AND PEACEBUILDING: A QUALITATIVE STUDY ON WOMEN INMATES IN MEXICAN PRISONS WITH A PEACEBUILDING PERSPECTIVE

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Introduction

Mexico is one of the 25 least peaceful nations in the world (IEP, 2022). Despite being governed for many years by three distinct political parties, this situation has not changed. In reality, structural and systemic issues are what lead to an absence of peace. Studying the connections between gender and peacelessness, the crimes committed by women, their circumstances of confinement, and their chances of reintegration are thus important topics to consider to comprehend this dysfunctional system. There is a wealth of literature on issues like gender inequality and structural gendered violence, as well as the connections between these things and the commission of crimes by women, the reasons why women commit crimes, the kinds of crimes they commit, and the circumstances under which women are imprisoned around the world, especially in Mexico. There isn't enough study, though, on how these problems connect to peacebuilding or how Mexican prisons wind up perpetuating the same patterns of violence that brought these women there in the first place, rather than serving as institutions that promote peacebuilding from a gender perspective.

The current study expands on a prior investigation conducted on women detained in three prisons in the State of Mexico (Meschoulam et al., 2020). That study was primarily concerned with examining the interviewees' opinions of the non-governmental organization-implemented labor and reinsertion programs in which they had taken part (hereafter, The Organization). However, the analysis of those interviews provided a wealth of information on topics like systemic gendered violence, the contribution of one or more men to the prospective conduct of the crime, or the association of the women interviewees with the commission of a crime. Additionally, that 2020 study demonstrated how the arrival of female prisoners and their time spent in Mexican jails may be examined from the viewpoint of the country's lack of peace from a gender perspective.

In light of this, and once more in partnership with the same social reinsertion group (The Organization), we designed the current study to explore those situations in greater depth and scope. The findings show a close connection between institutionalized gender-based violence and the incarceration of the women we spoke with. The violence that these women experience throughout their lives is part of the events and procedures that bring them to prison, and it then continues to occur while they are incarcerated. This violence, which originates from the

structures and the base of the system, and is not always visible but still haunts, hurts, injures, and even kills (Galtung, 1985), is present throughout their lives. To put it another way, while investigating the relationship between structural gender violence and crime, we discovered that the same structural violence may also be closely linked to the interviewees' potential innocence, or at the very least, their self-perception of innocence. The pages that follow demonstrate how and why.

Literature Review

As we mentioned, there is abundant literature published on this subject.

This includes research carried out in Mexico and in other countries about the factors that lead women to offend, or the types of crimes that women commit more frequently (Azaola, 2020; Casanova, 2017; De la Peña, 2011; Hernández and Domínguez, 2009; Loinaz, 2014; Soldino, Romero-Martínez, and Moya-Albiol, 2016). This area has also been investigated from a mental health or addictions perspective (Colmenares et al., 2007; Romero & Aguilera, 2002).

Study has also been done to determine the relationship between machismo and delinquency (Moral de la Rubia and Ramos, 2016), as well as research that contrasts the use of violence or the perpetration of violent crimes by men and women (Azaola, 1999; Dardis et al., 2015). Some studies even go so far as to investigate whether there is a connection between having experienced gender-based violence in the past and committing crimes later on (Leonard, 2012).

Other topics include studies that contrast the lives of men and women in prison (Herrera & Expósito, 2010), study on the conditions of detained women in Mexico and other nations, as well as assessments of the quality of their lives (Azaola, 2007; Malacalza, 2012; Sanhueza, 2015). Studies have also looked into gender stereotypes in the jail setting (Cinelli, 2020). An intriguing question regarding Mexico is whether or not the country's prison system incorporates a gender perspective in the execution of sentences, offers resources and tools to help women confront and escape situations of gender-based violence, or whether it instead reproduces macho behavioral practices (Hayner & Richter, 1942; or more recently, Garrido, Azaola, & Yacamán, 1996). There are also investigations based on facts, as the report the National Human Rights Commission published on Mexico City's jails (CNDH, 2002).

Numerous research projects have examined the relationships between women, crime, and different types of punishment from a criminological perspective (Ariza & Iturralde, 2017). Alternatively, a lot of criminology-related research has examined how women who are incarcerated see their roles as mothers, both in Mexico (Contreras, 2018; Pávez, Mena, & Lobos, 2009; Rangel, 2020) and abroad (Mulchy et al., 2011; Mauersberger, 2016).

These are only a few illustrations of the breadth of research that has been done on both the commission of crimes by women and their incarceration. It is generally agreed upon in this literature that there is no one element that causes women to commit crimes; rather, it is a multifaceted and complex phenomenon that needs to be examined systemically. For instance, several Latin American studies on crimes involving emotional attachments tend to place more emphasis on women as victims of crime than as perpetrators of it (De la Peña, 2011). Accordingly, there is a ton of research that attempts to approach the problem from the standpoint

of structural gender violence (Price, 2012), or even studies that attempt to address the question, "Is violence against women an issue about women or about violence?" (Felson, 2006).

However, there aren't enough studies that look at such issues from the standpoint of peacebuilding. Studying gender violence is vital but insufficient to comprehend the phenomenon from a more systemic viewpoint that includes positive peace, i.e., the active components that produce and sustain peace, since peace is not limited to the absence of violence. Therefore, it becomes necessary to look at more complex issues in addition to "the factors that lead women to commit crimes," such as the presumption of their innocence, the possibility that they are imprisoned without realizing or accepting that they have committed any crimes, and the structural factors that contribute to their imprisonment and keeping them in that condition without having their legal situation resolved for very long periods of time (and how to transform those conditions). Particularly in Mexico, one of the least peaceful nations on earth, the combination of these variables with a thorough approach to the development of constructive peace with a gender perspective is most important. This research aims to advance that cause.

Research Questions

In order to better understand the connections between structural violence, structural gendered violence, crime and incarceration, in relation to peacebuilding with a gender perspective, the purpose of this research was to explore the perceptions of a sample of incarcerated women in 12 prisons located in different states of Mexico. It sought to provide answers to the following questions:

From the perception of a sample of incarcerated women in Mexico, how are the absence of structural peace, structural violence, and structural gendered violence linked to the potential perpetration of crimes by women, and the conditions of women's incarceration in Mexico? To what extent their role as women, as well as the roles played by one or more men in their lives, function as contributing or determining factors in their association with delinquency or crime? (This question originally spoke of "perpetration" of crime, but was modified to "association" upon observing, during the pilot interviews, the overwhelming self-perception among the interviewees of their innocence). What are their perceptions about their current situation and their future? How do the conditions under which they are incarcerated impact their emotional status, their possibilities for reparation, reinsertion, and reconstruction of the social fabric? To what extent do prisons in Mexico—one of the 25 most violent countries in the world—reproduce circumstances of structural and gendered violence, and fail to function as pillars for building peace in the country?

Finally, what recommendations can be drawn from this thematic exploration for the Mexican prison system to contribute to gender-sensitive peacebuilding in this country and perhaps in other parts of the world as well?

Methodology

Location

The 12 jails where the study's participants are incarcerated are where all the data was gathered. Coahuila, State of Mexico, Nuevo Leon, Oaxaca, Quintana Roo, and Queretaro are the states

where these twelve jails are situated. We were not permitted to interview individuals in private, thus observations and interviews were performed in public areas of the jail, such as courtyards, dining halls, or workstations. But every interview was set up such that there were as few interruptions as possible.

Participants and Sampling Strategy

In the 12 jails listed above, 33 female inmates were questioned. The Organization looked for jails across the nation during the research period in order to conduct the interviews. This search led to the scheduling of meetings, excursions, and locations where the interviewing crew eventually arrived. Thus, both the prisons and the participants in this research were selected randomly. Two participants were interviewed in prison A (we used letters to omit identifying data); 2 in prison B; 2 in prison C; 2 in prison D; 3 in prison E; 3 in prison F; 2 in prison G; 2 in prison H; 5 in prison I; 4 in prison J; 4 in prison K; and 2 in prison L. This sample, as is usual in qualitative research, does not seek to represent the entire population of incarcerated women in Mexico. Even so, an attempt was made to obtain the greatest possible diversity among participants. Therefore, we interviewed five women between 20 and 29 years of age; 12 between 30 and 39 years of age; 11 between 40 and 49 years of age; 3 between 50 and 59 years of age; and 2 between 60 and 69 years of age. No other selection or sampling criteria was used.

Each participant signed an informed consent form prior to their interview, and the security of the information provided complied with the ethical standards of the Universidad Iberoamericana. The procedures for contacting and recruiting participants, as well as for conducting the research, adhered to Mexican laws on privacy and personal data protection.

Data Collection

Data collection consisted of 33 in-depth individual interviews carried out face-to-face with each participant. All interviews were carried out in Spanish, the mother language of the participants. The research period was marked by the COVID-19 pandemic, which unfortunately prolonged the data collection process for 12 months. We employed a semi-structured interview protocol that was partly based on the literature study and partly intended to elicit in-depth information about the categories we wished to investigate. Due to the participants' propensity for feelings of innocence, the first interview protocol had to be amended, and the questions had to be revised to take it into account. The interviewers' various and in-depth inquiries were designed to elicit more information about the pertinent issues the interviewee was addressing. In certain instances, we were given permission to bring in electronic recording equipment for the interviews. Only four out of the 33 interviews revealed instances in which it was impossible. We chose to conduct the majority of the interviews in two-person teams both because of this, and in an effort to reduce bias. The interviewer only took notes about pertinent information. The second person recorded every statement and word the interviewee spoke as accurately as they could. Although it was impossible to register every word of every conversation when recording was prohibited, the interviewer pairs would meet and exchange notes to make sure the transcription was as accurate as feasible.

Additionally, during the majority of the visits, the two team members carefully observed the prison's outside and interior environments as well as the activities of the convicts in an effort to

complement the topics mentioned by the participants. The interviewers created a memo with two columns, one for their feelings throughout the observation and interview and the other for a detailed explanation of what they saw (Janesick, 2004).

Data Analysis

All interviews were transcribed and subsequently processed through the qualitative software *NVivo 12.0*. For the analysis, pre-existing categories (drawn from our previous research [Meschoulam et al., 2020], as well as from the literature review), as well as emergent categories were employed. In order to detect patterns and repetitions, words, sentences or whole paragraphs were selected and coded within these categories, as well as the emergence of new themes. Fourteen different people participated in the analyses. Each analysis was carried out by teams of two people in order to detect further coding elements. Moreover, the project leader reviewed the 100% of the analyses to make corrections, add coding elements, and ensure quality, and potential bias control throughout the process. As a result of the large number of pre-existing categories, training sessions and many revisions were needed prior to conducting each analysis. Moreover, during the data analysis, new categories emerged and were detected by the team.

Trustworthiness

This was a unique research study in terms of the emotional impact it had on each of the researchers. It would be dishonest to say that we remained entirely "neutral" to what we heard, observed, and experienced throughout the months of visiting the prisons. Therefore, this research must be read with that limitation. That said, we went to great lengths to ensure the reliability of the results we found. These included the following elements: (a) a combination of qualitative methodological tools that included not only the in-depth interviews, but also close observations in order to provide additional objective elements to be contrasted with the interviews; (b) interviews conducted in teams of two, and subsequent contrasting of the notes of those two individuals for bias control; (c) at the same time, the different interviews were conducted by 17 different people, which helped to control for potential individual biases; (d) the writing of the memos included the feelings and impressions of the researchers, often impacted by what they observed during several months of attending the prisons; this helped to control for potential biases due to these accumulated feelings; (e) in parallel, continuous meetings were held in which the team was present, to compare the information, share feelings, and contribute to the control of potential group biases; (f) tests were carried out to contrast the results from participants in the different prisons we worked at, as well as contrasts between age groups. After all these contrasts, the main patterns we found remain unchanged.

Transferability

This research offers results related exclusively to 33 incarcerated women in twelve prisons located in six states of the Mexican Republic. Even though the sample may have been as broad as possible, it still does not fully represent all of the prisoners who are housed in various jails or locations. As a result, these findings cannot be directly applied to other groups. However, the recurrence of patterns and their consistency with elements found in the literature, as well as the relevance of the themes that most stand out in the interviews and observations, seem to suggest

that this small sample has much to teach and contribute to the Mexican prison system and peacebuilding issues in general.

Results

General Overview

The categories that came up most frequently in the interviews will be listed first. We then break down those categories into thematic subcategories to examine the outcomes in more detail. Table 1 presents the themes most frequently repeated by the interviewees:

Table 1.0 *General Overview*

Categories	Number of coding references	Percentage of participants who mentioned it at least once
Structural Gender Violence	372	94%
Mention of profession/work prior to prison	240	91%
Existence of a support network	239	94%
Inconsistencies or failures in the detention or legal process	229	97%
Perception of injustice	210	94%
Mention of ties or emotions related to relatives, present before confinement	190	64%
Emotional abuse	190	73%
Visits or lack of visits	188	97%
I am innocent/not guilty	188	82%
Gender stereotypes	185	91%
Disintegrated/dysfunctional family nucleus	180	79%
Gender-related physical violence	168	79%
Mention of basic needs (water, food, lack of space, medical services, hygiene products, menstrual products).	152	100%

The thematic dispersion, or the very broad complexity of our sample, the complexity of the factors that make up the interviewees' lives prior to their incarceration, and the various points of view and perspectives that make up each case are perhaps the first things that stand out from our overall findings. There is no singular story, as our interviews with individuals who were located

in twelve different jails around the nation demonstrate. The table shows that some of these individuals' stories reveal a great deal about their employment or professions before going to prison, and in some cases they had extensive and reliable support networks because of, essentially, formed family relationships that had developed over the course of their life. On the other hand, there are accounts of physical or overt domestic violence or gender-based abuse in other situations, which are mirrored in the absence of these support networks.

In other words, the findings point to a multivariate phenomenology that requires more in-depth review to identify the features that these stories appear to have in common. This was the task of the analysis of the interviews and this is what is relevant to highlight:

1. The most recurrent theme in our interviews is ***Structural Gender Violence***, that is, violence that comes from the structures of the system, which is not always visible to us, but which always harms, attacks, prejudices, stereotypes, discriminates, and frequently ends up facilitating or giving permission to a more direct and visible violence. This type of violence, which emanates from the system itself, underlies the stories they tell us and permeates almost all the interviews. This category received 374 mentions (frequency or "f") and is present in 94% of our interviews. Typical examples of these mentions include the following:

"My father did treat me differently. He told me 'You don't make progress because you are a woman'. When I was taken out of school and my father got married, I told him 'Dad, I want to continue studying. I want to study'. I have always liked to study, I wanted to be a doctor. And I tell him 'I want to be a doctor, dad'. 'Nonsense! Learn to do your housework because for washing diapers and cooking food you don't need a school degree of anything'. I said 'Well, that's fine'. Yes, that's how my father was. He always made women less. 'Men are the ones who should study because they are the ones who are going to provide'. But no, no, that's not true. We should both study. Both men and women, because we are responsible, both men and women." Participant 13

"I never talked to anyone. I kept everything to myself. Once I told my grandmother: 'Mom, I have problems with X because he goes out with women and all that'. And she says: 'You leave him alone, he is a man, he belongs to the street, you belong at home. You should say nothing'. No. 'But, I'd better separate from him', and she said: 'And where are you going? Do you have anywhere to go?' 'No. Well, you are right. You better put up with it then'." Participant 13

"That you can't talk to other men, that you don't go out in the street at such hours because a woman who is a lady of her house should not go out in the street. Like right now when I am here, sometimes when I talk to him and I curse or something like that, he says 'No, don't contaminate yourself, you are not the same as other women, you are a lady'. I mean, it's like... yes, he is one of those men who think like that. And now that I'm working, I just started working in fabric creation, I've been working for about a week. And it's like every day (he tells me): 'What are you working for, it's so cold!' and I tell him 'Let me go! I want to work'." Participant 21

"I mean, because we are not... we are not taken into consideration. We always, I mean we see it more than anything else in terms of visits. If you go to a men's prison, the waiting line is huge and women are always the ones who go there, but you go to a women's prison, and.... most of the visitors who come are our parents, mothers, fathers, but partners...those are very few. There are people whose partners have left them here abandoned. It's like a man can't stand the loneliness, I don't know, and then he looks for another woman." Participant 11

2. As we said, beyond the narrative related to their previous jobs or professions, or the presence of important support networks, the frequency with which the participants assumed themselves as innocent is very striking. This is perhaps one of the major findings of this research. In researching the literature, we originally sought to answer "Why do women commit a crime?" or "How do their gender role, gendered structures of domination and power, or the involvement of one or more men play a role as causal or contributing factors in their commission of crimes?" In contrast, from the first interviews, we found that most of interviewees claimed that they were not responsible for the commission of the crimes of which they were accused. This changed our approach.

In that sense, eight out of ten interviewees frequently spoke to us about their innocence (this theme was repeated 188 times during the 33 interviews). Thus, 94% of our participants perceive themselves to be victims of a high level of injustice during their trial or legal processes (f=210), and almost all of them, even those who recognize themselves as guilty, spoke frequently about the inconsistencies or failures in their detention or in their legal process (f=229). Later in the discussion, we will talk about the implications of these factors for the purposes of what we were originally seeking to explore. Consider the following examples to better understand this issue:

"And the day the judge said that it was the last time we would be in the prosecutor's office, I was happy because I said 'I'm not going to jail', well, then a stranger arrived. And he says that I was the person watching for him (during his kidnapping) ...I don't even know him! ... and I said 'You're lying because you're under oath and you're lying. Because at my forty-five years of age, when I was arrested, I had never met you before'. And as I told the judge, 'I am here to speak for me, I am not here to speak for my brother or for this stranger, I am here to speak for me. Whether they did it or not, I don't know for sure. I only come to say that I am innocent because I do not know this person, he is lying. Carry out an investigation, go to my house, talk to my neighbors because this does not make any sense, and the years you are assigning me to serve, make no sense at all'. That was and still is what hurt me the most." Participant 14

"Maybe I can say that things happened for a reason. I am innocent, of course I am innocent. But I also say that now I have become very close to God, and now I know that only God knows why He brought me here, why I have recovered my husband, I have recovered my family..." Participant 20

"It's unfair, all of this!... because I've been here for so long, and without having committed the crime. Without having done it. If I was aware that I did it, I would

be okay with it. But I didn't. I'm losing my best years and my children's recovery because of this asshole.” Participant 18

“I mean, there are many anomalies in the process. I always say so. And the lawyer recently told me that if someone had seen my process from the beginning, if they had done the accumulation of files, I would already be out. I told them 'I did not study law. I am here because I am a 'criminal', because I did not study. You are the ones who have to take care of that, not me'. I said 'and now seven years later you come to tell me that if someone had taken care of that four years ago, I would already be free... you are supposed to defend me, not the other way around! I mean, what, I have to spend 48 years here because of your ineptitude? I can't go free'. They said 'no, no, but don't see it that way...', 'how can I not see it that way?', I say, 'I have two children waiting for me outside and my wife'.” Participant 33

“And the first time I saw my mother was at the first audience ... and that was when my mother told me that for her, I was dead, right? Because I left my children again. I mean, she told me when we saw each other, 'I just gave you your children, you have them, and you do your shit', and I said: 'I didn't do anything! I didn't do it! I'm here unjustly, he knows I didn't do it, why did he do it? I don't know!'.” Participant 18

“A friend of mine was here with me, but she left because of legal protection. She was here for two years. And she left on a legal protection that cost her 130 thousand pesos and.... the corrupt lawyer who took her out... I say 'corrupt' because I didn't know he was taking her case, and he made me sign two blank paper sheets. And then, later I found out, a little while ago, that those signed papers by me were filled out in the handwriting of I don't know whom, because it's not my handwriting, they put that I plead as the only person guilty of the crime of homicide and robbery of a house.” Participant 13

“I am fighting them over... what I am asking for is a sentence [her voice is cut off] because I think it is unfair that it is already ten years, and... I am paying... nothing. It's been ten years of my life that I haven't seen my family grow and the truth is that nobody can help me, and I only ask for a sentence because I am here for an alleged homicide, and if they sentence me with twenty-five years I get to leave with half, and I already have ten, but nobody can help me.” Participant 19

3. The table above reflects, additionally, that beyond the possible existence of support networks or strong family ties, there is a high frequency of themes associated with gender-based violence in the lives of the participants. Emotional abuse was mentioned on 190 occasions by seven of each ten participants. Gender stereotypes of various kinds were repeated in nine of each ten interviews (f=185), and almost 80% of our participants spoke of disintegrated nuclear families and physical gender-based violence as a central part of their personal stories. These are some examples:

"I got rheumatoid arthritis, and because of all the medicine the doctors gave me, I practically lost one of my kidneys. I was already urinating blood. And my liver, because of so much medication, began to deteriorate. Then, my husband fought with me a lot. He would tell me, 'Drop dead, you wretch, drop dead. I hate you, die' already'. He says 'you make me spend the little money we have'. Well, he was a merchant. He made good money. 'You make me spend a lot of money, die!'. Or 'go away, with your family!'. And 'how much do you want me to pay you in order for you to go? And go away! He was very upset that I was sick. Then he told me he wanted us to separate. But where was I supposed to go? I couldn't walk. I was dragging my feet. And, full of panic, completely, full of panic, because with so much medicine they gave me, my liver died and one of my kidneys died. They wanted to take out my kidney. So, the man practically hated me." Participant 13

"Previously he himself raped me like eight, nine times before I got pregnant, but his threats made me so afraid, and not being able to talk, and trying to commit suicide. There was one suicide attempt. One moment I was riding my bicycle and I jumped in the middle of the road, but luckily the car stopped and didn't kill me, but yes, the sexual abuse attempt he made was an attempt to kill me, nothing else, and he told me 'If you tell your mom or your brothers, your brothers will be left without a father, and you don't want that, do you?' Why? Why that threat and why the fear involved? Because I didn't have a father either, I didn't know what a father was, a hug, a kiss. I mean, to this day I don't know who he is, I only know his first and last name." Participant 18

"That day when he hit me, I was short of breath and the more I was short of breath, the tighter he squeezed my neck and I told him 'I can't breathe' and he said that will be helpful for you" and he squeezed me more. When I could, I pushed him away and he kicked me, but all I did was cover my face. I didn't want him to hit me in the face. I told him 'wherever you want, but not in the face, I don't want my family to see me like that'. So he grabbed my head, he hit me on the ground, he kicked me, he said 'oh, aren't you going to die?' and he grabbed his gun and started to play Russian roulette on my head but I think... I don't know how that works, so I think that when it was the last chance and the bullet was already there, he said 'no, you're not even worth one of my bullets'." Participant 3

"The last chance I had with him was in Tulum, we lived in Tulum. In the car, he opened the door and tried to throw me out of the car just because I grabbed the baby girl, I carried her and told him 'Come on, throw me out, throw me out, but you're going to throw me out with your daughter and everything'. Because that way I knew he wasn't going to throw me out. And he told me 'You want to kill my daughter' and I told him, 'No. Come on, throw me out'. Because it was the only way he wasn't going to do anything to me. But yes, that was the last time that happened." Participant 23

"He had a machete and two knives... well, what do you think he had those for? To make mincemeat out of me, but I didn't know that... First of all, he wasn't

threatening me. No, he was just insisting that I should drink with him, and when I told him I didn't want to drink, he started to touch me with the machete.”
Participant 31

Thematic Subcategories

The following are results by each thematic subcategory for a closer analysis.

A. Women's life in prison

As was the case in our previous research (Meschoulam et al., 2020), participants continuously referred to topics such as visits, their basic needs, and issues related to their daily lives. As we stated above, the sample under investigation demonstrated the predominance of complexity among the 12 jails where we worked. Many of the interviewees spoke about their visits, which is related to what was said before regarding their support systems. However, another section discussed how visits became progressively less frequent over time. All participants generally mentioned their fundamental requirements at least occasionally, with a particular emphasis on the scarcity of water, medical care, hygiene supplies, or menstrual products. This topic was mentioned 152 times throughout the 33 interviews. In a similar vein, given that the interviews took place during the COVID-19 pandemic, this issue recurred frequently ($f=124$; 97% of participants mentioned it at least once), though the majority of the comments referred to the lack of sanitation or protective measures during the epidemic.

Interestingly, 97% of respondents mentioned having a good relationship with inmates or guards ($f=126$), while fewer (85%; $f=103$) talked about their conflicts, disputes or fights. Nevertheless, it is important to note that many of the participants are part of reintegration programs; 97% of interviewees talked about their work in prisons, which includes sewing, knitting, cooking, or other work, in addition to the fact that six out of 10 participants talked about the assistance of some civil society organization ($f=82$); 85% talked about their participation in sports or recreational activities and 67% referred to their resilience or adaptation. Therefore, it seems that to the extent that the participants felt assisted in some way, or found some productive work, to that extent there are chances that they will have positive experiences, even under the complicated conditions of imprisonment in which they live. These are typical mentions of this subcategory:

“And well, as I said, my children are fine. And I also want to say, thanks also to the associations, because in prison X there were associations such as A or B, many associations in... also the Christian and Catholic churches that looked at me and helped me with my children in terms of education. And in terms of food, they also help me. Organization A also helps me with my children's education, and with the psychologists as well, thank God. They help each of the girls every month. I can tell you that I am very blessed because it is not the first time that A helps me. It has been four times that they have given me this support, and I also look for a way to ensure that my children are well here, and that my mother has food. Because A helps her with food too.” Participant 20

"A lawyer brought a project through which all those small fines are going to be paid so that all those people can leave. They tell me that they don't even have enough money to leave. I told them 'Well, we're going to make a little saving fund, everyone who you helped fix their pants, are going to pay you. Don't worry if you don't have enough, don't worry about it'. But the point is that we all participate, we are aware that we have to support each other. That there is a unification among all women, that there is sorority among us." Participant 22

"We teach each other. For example, if someone new arrives, 'Oh, come. I'm going to teach you this or that' and they start, like that, that's how I learned. My partner is the one who taught me, she told me 'You have to learn well. Look, sometimes when you burn the thread you can't see it, do it this way'." Participant 11

However, as we have explained, the complexity of the sample with which we worked also portrays a reality of deficiencies, conflicts, disputes and corruption, a reality in which, while in prison, women have to buy almost everything they need, which generates internal mafias, and illegal merchandise trafficking.

"The place is very small, 'small town, big hell' they say (saying in Spanish). There is a lot of bickering, it's complicated. They beat each other up... There is a lot of violence, believe it or not, there is, because of nonsense things like: 'she looked at me in a bad way', 'she told me I was speaking about her', 'she wants to steal my girlfriend'." Participant 10

"When I arrived at the X prison, it did not go well for me since the beginning. Again, I was beaten there. Not because of the guards, but because of the people who were in charge there. Because there were people who were in charge, inmates who were in charge. I was hit again and again. I was thrown from the stairs from the fourth floor. I went to the nurse office with a neck brace." Participant 19

"There are times, for example yesterday, the day before yesterday, that they gave rotten beans. When it's good, we do eat, when it's not, we have to cook something." Participant 11

"They treat us really bad in here. They see you as the worst. Here we are not going to receive help from anyone, there are no friends here. We are colleagues here, but nobody is going to take care of you, nobody is going to give you bath soap, nobody is going to help you at all." Participant 14

"We all have to generate (money). Some of them with the telephone, they extort, prostitute themselves, we all have to produce money. There is no way to survive if you don't. Or if your family doesn't support you." Participant 15

"They almost always feed us with potatoes and beans. The food is very bad, it is badly cooked. And the meat and chicken are poor quality ... Besides, they don't give you enough vegetables. They bring three kilos of tomato for 100 people and

for the whole week. They serve the same as when we were 50 people and they bring in the same quantity. And I know this because I used to help in the kitchen.” Participant 19

“It's just that... Well, when they can't bring us money, we, the ones who have been abandoned, we have to buy pads, toilet paper, shampoo, toothpaste, tooth brushes... it is an expense that we have to cover as nobody bring us money.” Participant 18

B. Emotional Situation of the interviewees

In this subcategory we grouped mentions related to the emotional situation of the women interviewed, which is one of the topics that is frequently discussed in the literature. We look at this area, nevertheless, from a different point of view: Positive peace also encompasses emotional well-being (Ekanola, 2012). In this regard, it is impossible to imagine establishing peace in a setting where this emotional well-being is not seriously considered.

We found a marked sentiment of injustice due to the living conditions of the majority of the interviewees; 64% of participants reported experiencing this feeling at least once ($f=82$); 55% expressed their sadness at not being able to see friends or family. Similarly, more than half narrated their state of shock, confusion or depression due to their imprisonment; four out of 10 mentioned their anxiety and, again, almost half reported their emotional burnout ($f=47$).

“The first months were very difficult. Since I arrived in December, Christmas was already upon us, and being away from my children was like a shock. I thought very ugly things, I did not understand what was happening.” Participant 6

“When we were separated... he started talking and talking... I can't tell my mom because she feels bad, or a friend because she can tell me ‘You're weak’... I feel suffocated already, always the same every day, problems here or there. Everything has fed me up. It's been a short time, four years.” Participant 10

“Not anymore, I can't stand it anymore, I can't stand the mistreatment from... I know it's their job, I know they're here for that, but sometimes it is just like, 'let me go!' I know I'm paying for something, what else? I'm locked up in a jail, I'm far from home, I don't have my children, I don't have my mother, that's it, I'm alone here. Locked up. I mean, what else?” Participant 25

“I have hired many lawyers and the truth is that they have all taken from us nothing more than money and money and money. I ask God for help, a lot. God is my only hope here, really, because it is very unfair to me to be locked up for ten years when nothing I am accused of is true, and without being sentenced. I'm not asking to be released, I'm just asking for a sentence to know what to do, because my hands are tied right now.” Participant 19

However, this thematic subcategory once more reflected the sample's complexity. Seven out of 10 interviewees told us about their learnings while incarcerated ($f=64$); 45% mentioned having positive feelings ($f=82$); and almost half talked about their rehabilitation and readaptation. It is important to note that some individuals' motivation was heavily influenced by their religious convictions, which was the case for 48% of them. In most of the references to positive feelings, learnings, and motivation, it is possible to observe that these particular interviewees participate in different programs such as paid labor, workshops, courses, or reintegration projects. Here is a typical mention related to this last section:

"I believe that these nine years that I have spent in prison, have been a lot of learning, and believe me that in prison you learn to value everything: family, your freedom, the things you used to do before. You learn to value everything every day. Even a plate of food you can say to yourself 'I miss food at home, that someone cooks for me'. You miss that too. And I believe that if God allowed to be free again, I would come out a different person and with a lot of learning." Participant 24

C. Socio-economic Background

As previously stated, the interviewees spent a significant portion of their conversations with us discussing their previous jobs or professions; however, this is where the story becomes complicated. While a majority of them (55%) talked about their economic struggles on 106 different occasions, and their lack of employment or opportunities, nearly half of the participants (48%) claimed to have experienced a material well-being (which, at least in our sample, suggests that there is no immediate correlation between a lack of environment and being imprisoned). Notwithstanding, this must be understood in light of the fact that gender violence, which was the most frequently discussed theme in the interviews, can take many different forms and is not always visible. Leadership role in the family economy is one of the categories that recur in almost half of the participants.

Examples of such mentions include:

"I lived very well, worked a lot. Since I was 17, I started working, that's why I stopped studying for a while. Later, I started working in a company with an uncle who helped me study a bachelor degree in computer science. I studied for two years. But then, I no longer liked the way my uncle was exploiting me and I stopped working with him...I worked all day and studied." Participant 15

"I used to go out at night to work. Unfortunately, I met a person who was introduced to me, I thought he had business and we got to know each other, and almost always the clients I had were very, very frequent... More than anything to support my children, right? I worked for my children, not for myself, not for clothing brands, nor for drugs, nor for drinks. No. I never used drugs or anything. It was simply to feed my children, and move forward." Participant 20

D. Personal Background

Our interview protocol also explored topics such as their family environments, the bonds forged throughout their lives, their partners and family situations. In general, there were a lot of mentions of this theme, indicating that these topics are clearly relevant to them.

Of these mentions, the category with the highest frequency (present in 94% of interviewees; $f=239$) demonstrates the existence of support networks before their incarceration or even while in prison. The high recurrency of this theme not only indicates the real or material existence of these networks, but also the importance that the participants place on this topic, which also seems to be reflected in the existence of links or ties, primarily family, that were part of their lives prior to being imprisoned ($f=190$ in 64% of participants).

Nevertheless, in keeping with the pattern of complexity revealed in this series of interviews, eight out of ten participants told us about the dissolution, dysfunction, or disintegration of their family ($f=180$), and 70% reported lack of support network. It is important to emphasize that this does not reflect contradictions in qualitative research, as we are not conducting surveys, but rather in-depth interviews that do not project white or black categories, but rather themes that are present to varying degrees and at various stages of the lives of the imprisoned women that we interviewed. Therefore, it is natural that some categories that may seem contradictory appear in the same conversation, and sometimes in the same paragraph. Thus, seven out of ten of them ($f=141$) disclosed their emotional or affective instability, six out of ten ($f=123$) talked about domestic violence, 50% told us about alcoholism and drug addiction in their lives, and 42% talked about their childhood and/or adolescence suffering.

Examples of this series of categories include the following:

"It is a two-story house; my parents live upstairs and I live downstairs. When I went to work, they looked after the children, so they were never alone. We always supported each other as family. They stayed with their grandparents and I went to work, and I came back and fed them." Participant 23

"My dad bought a sound system. I was in high school and my friends and I liked to play the guitar or sing. I asked my dad to borrow the sound system and we were all happy to play in an event with it. It turns out that the event was not held that planned day, and I asked for it for another day. It turns out that my dad had an event that same day at the church and since I had the equipment, the priest asked him about the speakers. I still try to forget about that moment, but he got very angry because I couldn't bring all the equipment the same day because it was already late and everything got complicated. In the end my mom got angry and so my dad, because he needed it. The next day my dad came for me. I was asleep and I heard him enter the room, closed the door. When I saw him, I knew it was over for me. My dad beat me very badly that day, it was horrible. The worst is that my mom saw this, and she did nothing. She told me that he was the macho of the house, that I made him look like an idiot, and that I couldn't be trusted. That I should put away those silly ideas of studying, because we were fighting a lot for the career I had chosen, she supported me but he didn't." Participant 10

“At the age of 15, my stepfather raped me and that's where my first son came from, the oldest. After he was born, I left. I had to leave the house. There was never a conversation with my mom, right now there is hardly any approach. But there was never a hug, an 'I love you', nothing, it was always a feeling of 'it's your fault and it was you'. When I told my mom that it was him, she did not believe me. On the contrary, she slapped me and she told me: How was it possible that I had messed with her husband? And I told her 'No'. At 15 or 16 years old I gave birth, I had my baby, I had him for about 5 or 6 months. As it was rape, and he was a product of it, I rejected him, right? At first, that's when I started drinking. I went out into the street, I lived on the street for a long time, I got over myself.” Participant 18

E. Situation of Legal Process

This was the second thematic subcategory with the highest number of repetitions during the interviews, indicating once more the significance this topic holds for the people we interviewed. What is relevant, however, lies in the story that is told from this table of results: a brutal perception of injustice in their process ($f=210$), essentially due to inconsistencies or failures both in their detention and in their legal process ($f=229$) present in practically the entire sample. In other words, the participants, during their interview, spent enough time talking about their innocence (eight out of ten claim to be innocent) and the violence with which they were treated by the system. They are imprisoned, as they perceive, due to a series of concatenated injustices. Most (97%; $f=150$) complained about lack of access to a lawyer or a competent lawyer, or about bureaucratic or administrative negligence (79%; $f=108$), but not just negligence. Also, the majority of them (60%) pointed out the abuse of power, and seven out of ten made reference to the system's pervasive corruption.

This portrays a system that is not only careless but also deprives them of their freedom as a result of administrative flaws, mistakes made due to a lack of expertise, or accidents. It conveys to us a sense of pervasive, almost organized violence that springs from the structures, a violence that allows, facilitates, and benefits many people; and indeed, a violence intimately linked to their gender. It is evidenced by mentions like these:

“They stripped me naked for a whole day, everyone came in, but I had a blindfold on. Hands behind and feet bandaged. They kept me naked but I do not know how long because I lost consciousness. They put a bag on me, they sprayed pepper spray on me, it was horrible. It was for me to confess but I didn't know what they wanted me to say. The truth is, if I had known what they wanted me to say, I would have said it from the beginning because what they did to us was horrible. No one knew anything, just the man—the reason I am here (jail)—and other guys who were never found, they never found anyone. They had me naked, all the officers entered, there were 8 officers and 8 anti-kidnapping officers from Cuautitlán. And there, all of them came and molested me, hit me, kicked me, spit on me, peed on me, everything. So, my mom brought me clothes, because they said I was already very dirty. My mom came and I put some pants on, with that they took me to a press conference, then all the people “involved”, including me, were standing still all day. They sat us down because they beat us and threw us

around and hit us. They took us to a park and tied us to a tree and there, they drowned us with water and beat us. They didn't even ask us anything anymore, because we didn't know anything. I told a person how everything had happened and told me 'You signed the paper, confirming you did everything'. I told him that I didn't sign nothing, and he told me 'Here is your signature that you did everything and that you planned and called them' and that there, they agreed to the kidnapping, and then I called them in (I don't know where) and that I called five others. I don't remember signing anything. I remember that the last day, my mother came to see me in a room and there was the general attorney, a fat old man. He looked at me so harshly. They say that the record was drawn up that day, where I allegedly signed, but I didn't see anything." Participant 15

"I had a public attorney. But I never knew who he was. I saw one, two... then none. I just stood there alone, like a fool. I mean, I never knew who he was, really. And now, before they sentenced me, the judge called me. A man of average height, with a broad forehead...He calls me and says: 'ma'am, I do not find any crime involving you. Neither you, nor your children, I do not find any crime. In the morning, I want 150,000 pesos and the three of you will be absolved'. And I tell him 'But I don't have that money'. And he says to me: 'Don't you have the money?' And I tell him 'No'. 'And your family?' I told him, 'I don't think so, they're angry with me, because they say why don't I speak out, why don't I tell the truth. And I can't talk, I can't say anything. And he says: 'So what do I do?'. I replied, "Well, sentence us, we have no other option." And he says, 'Fine'. He turns around, and leaves. And they did sentence us. My children were accused of house robbery. My son, car theft. How is he going to steal that old van that is falling apart? I mean, it's illogical. The x and the x (police), later I found out that they went to hide the van at my son's bakery. How illogical, right? It was not coherent. How a young man, who is not so economically fluent, is going to steal a van that is falling apart." Participant 13

"They (the officers) took us up, they took a long time to take us away, I was very afraid, I just thought 'Don't rape me, don't rape me'. I was very afraid. They intimidated us and told us things. I didn't know where my friend was because I didn't feel her around, only some officers, they're only taking me. What's going on? I felt that we arrived at a place, from the back. I tried to see but I couldn't, I was walking on the floor but I don't know if it was a house or a building. We got to the separation cells. I don't know how much time passed by, but I was scared to death. They didn't rape, me but they did point a gun at me. I got there, I was sitting and serious. At that moment I blocked myself. Since the officers entered the hotel, from that moment I blocked myself. I do not know what happened, right now I am crying like this because I get angry, but outside, I cannot even cry. My friend tells me to take it out, that I have no feelings, to cry. But I cannot." Participant 10

Table 2.0: Situation of Legal Process.

Categories	Number of references	Percentage of participants who mentioned it at least once
Inconsistencies or failures in the detention or legal process	229	97%
Perception of injustice	210	94%
I am innocent/mentions of not guilty	188	82%
Access or lack of access to a competent legal person	150	97%
Administrative-bureaucratic negligence in the legal process	108	79%
Abuse of authority and power	99	61%
Corrupt judicial system	66	70%
Mentions about the Sentence	56	79%
Legal Protection	42	45%
Lengthy Prison Sentence	41	64%

F. Family implications

A portion of the literature cited above addresses the effects that imprisoning women has on their families. Therefore, the extent to which this thematic subcategory emerged in our conversations with inmates was a part of the focus of the present study. Their roles as mothers were the most frequently mentioned. This category was repeated 119 times; eight out of ten interviewees mentioned it at least once. In this regard, emotional repercussions of separation, the participants' hope and motivation to see their children again, and for a third of the participants, references to motherhood in prison appear to be the most prominent impacts. Additionally, 67% of respondents expressed resentment for being physically separated from their children or other family members (f=51). Typical examples include the following:

"I have a lot of faith to get them back when I get out. I'm mentally prepared for that, because my son, the boy, doesn't know that I am his mother. The person who is looking after him treats him well, like a son. I know I have every right, but I don't know if I have the courage to claim him as mine, I don't know how he will feel. The girls, their aunt manipulates them so that they don't talk to me. It is valid, they are grownups now, whoever wants to be with me, will be with me. I would be delighted for everyone to be there." Participant 12

"What has affected me the most, is emotionally, because of what I was telling you about my family, I am very attached to my family. And even more when it comes to my son. I knew that he was hospitalized and would have liked to be with him. Even now, was something I was talking about with my friend a while ago, it's still something I regret." Participant 17

In this regard, the participants' perceptions of financial, health, and family issues as being directly related to their time in prison stand out; 73% of the interviewees mentioned this at least once (f=65). Here are some examples:

"Look, at the beginning it was very hard, because they were children. I left my son when he was 8 and my daughter when she was 6, they were not babies, but they were not that old either. It was very hard, they were in therapy, they had them... well, my mom was...I don't know, I don't know how she had them understand my situation." Participant 5

"Sometimes I tell her that I do have what I need, even if I don't have anything, so that she doesn't have to worry or spend money on me. I mean, I tell her that because she's already worried and burnt out. All the expenses, or that the lawyer asks for money...So, when many people say 'oh, why are you selling stuff if you don't need to because you have visits (meaning she receives economic support)'. Yes, but that has nothing to do with it. I mean, they already do enough by coming, paying for gas, or bringing me something to eat, for me to take even more from them, well, no. That's why when they want to leave me money, I don't take it. Sometimes I tell them, 'No, I do have soap', or 'yes, I do have softener' or something like that so they don't worry about it or spend money on that. So, I buy it here, but it is more expensive at the store. Yes, the truth is that it is more expensive because there is no other way but to buy it here." Participant 11

Nevertheless, to add complexity to the picture we have painted, it is important to note that on 86 occasions, 61% of participants spoke to us about the emotional support they receive from their relatives or support circle, which makes it easier for them to communicate with their children. For most of them, this factor is substantial for adapting to the environment in which they live.

G. Direct Gender Violence

A significant part of our discussion with the participants was focused on this theme subcategory. It refers to direct gender-based violence manifested through assaults and interactions that cause material and/or emotional harm. The presence of these issues appeared as part of their lives prior to being imprisoned and also during their incarceration.

In this regard, 73% of participants told us, on 190 occasions, about various forms of emotional abuse they had experienced in their lives. Eight out of ten (f=168) mentioned having been subjected to physical violence, and almost a third mentioned having been subjected to sexual violence. Their gender is linked to all of this violence. It is particularly noteworthy that the family is a breeding ground for gender violence in 40% of them. Unfortunately, issues like these are not uncommon in a nation like Mexico. Nevertheless, it was essential to examine the extent to which such categories appeared in the conversations we had with the participants in a project that aims to link these factors with peacebuilding. Here are some examples:

"I suffered a lot with him because he beat me; at that time, he was a very hard person with me and with my children. And always, when I was with him, he said

he would change, but he did not change. He would hit me again and I would separate from him again. That is, I lived with him, and I separated from him. And it was at that time when all this detention happened. He arrived and asked me for forgiveness at prison X after five months, and told me that if everything happened it was his fault too. He told me that he missed me a lot. And now that man is also coming to see me." Participant 20

"I didn't want to be without my children's father because, what would the family say? I put up with a lot. So much so, that...my family stopped hearing from me for about 3 months because he kept me locked in a construction room in his own house and wouldn't let me go out, because I was going to leave with the child. I never thought of going anywhere with the child, but... he was in bad shape. And he would pass me the food under the door, and it was like a trauma. But I'm not going to lie to you, I got used to that trauma. I preferred to continue with that trauma and not let him leave me. In other words, I told him 'It doesn't matter, I forgive you, nothing happens, I forget. Don't go, don't leave me'." Participant 25

"The problem was that since I came from my parents' mistreatment, beatings and all that, for me, he was like a help, to get married and make a life with a person to leave behind beatings, mistreatment, violence, all that. But instead of my life being better, it was worse. Because as I come from violence, he saw me being beaten and then it was easy for him to beat me. One day before my wedding, he hit me. I thought he was going to change. He never changed. He kept hitting me. He had my children, he treated me badly, he told me I was one of the worst, so there was always a lack of respect. When he used to make food, he would throw the food. There was a lot of abuse, so much abuse that I went to a church, and there a pastor told me 'Look, what God unites, man does not separate, but I separate you. Go away. I don't want to see you dead,' because there was already so much abuse." Participant 23

"Personally, I never saw him as a partner, I saw him with fear, he scared me...Several times I tried to leave, pack and go somewhere else but he threatened me, he pulled knives on me, that he was going to kill me, that I could not leave. That's what the situation was like." Participant 4

H. Structural Gender Violence

If we had to highlight only one thematic subcategory within the entire study, it would be that of *Structural Gender Violence*. As explained earlier, this category had the highest number of repetitions throughout this study ($f=372$ in 94% of respondents). However, proper examination of how other categories include this phenomenon is incredibly instructive:

First and foremost, nine out of ten interviewees mentioned the prevalence of gender stereotypes in their environment on 185 occasions. Seven out of ten revealed their gender identity and emphasized their subjectivity as women in the interviews we had with them. Specifically, this

refers to how the interviewees live their own experiences as humans and as subjects, and how they see and perceive their roles. This theme recurred on 120 occasions.

"No, there was no choice. He had to be super relaxed with me. He hit me hard when I didn't know how to cook. I used to tell him 'My mother always did everything for us', and he would say to me: 'Well, your mother is not here right now'. I didn't know how to wash, so he beat me. I didn't know how to cook, so he hit me. I didn't know how to sweep, he hit me. So, you learn, you learn. You don't know how to make flour tortillas? Ah, how the hell not?' Go do it! It was very macho." Participant 26

"Like for example... I was always looking for goals. To accomplish them. Every purpose, I achieved it, but there was always a man who I would hear say: 'How can I let a woman, and apart from being a woman, a butch woman, boss me around? In a way, it did make me insecure, but it also made me a little stronger, to not let them push me around and to show that I can be much more than them." Participant 29

"I consider that my life was normal; I was a housewife, I took my children to school, to the house, normal. Well, what a stay-at-home mother does, that is, she devotes herself to her children, to her home. When I was alone, I dedicated myself to work. I washed, washed dishes, took care of my children, took them to school." Participant 21

"No, it's always the same people. It's not husbands, it's their moms. There are more women who come to see women. There (in the men's prison) there are a lot of women who come to see men. That's where that part being a woman comes in, where she is more... I don't know... I don't want to generalize, but that empathy or love, because we are more foolish. A woman I think will be unconditional, the woman is supportive, and kind. When a woman is in the same situation the man goes away, he leaves her alone. We women are more than that, we are always there. That's why men have more visitors, their mom, wife, sisters, etc." Participant 10

"Well, I feel that I did well for being a woman, because of what I dedicated myself to. I mean, with my uncle I feel that he thought I was cute, or I don't know but everyone helped me and taught me how to do things. When I worked at the Palace, it was bad for me because I was a woman, because all the women were against each other, all the secretaries against each other. Then they were mean to me, if I was a minute late or if I stopped to use the bathroom they would say things about me, things like that. And in the taxi drivers, on the contrary, I feel that I opened myself a way being a woman because it is a man's world. And I was the only woman." Participant 15

Second, gender inequality was mentioned by 70% of our participants as being present in their lives and environments. The systemic forms of gendered violence to which we have referred include inequality. These are typical mentions in this context:

"He did go out with his friends. Sometimes he would leave work and go out. And he would come back late, he would come back at 11, 12 o'clock at night. And well, I was alone in the house. Because if you say 'well, don't enjoy yourself...'. Well, I wanted to go out, but I couldn't because I had to look after my daughter. Or I had to go to work early, so I had to go to bed early. So, he was doing something else, and I was doing something else." Participant 25

"Because he always... He knew that I had a hard time, literally, getting up at four, five o'clock in the morning, getting ready, getting my daughter ready. He would be there from eight to four and I would get up, prepare his uniform, breakfast, and by seven in the morning I had to go to the bridge to cross, to be at school at 7:45 a.m. I still had a friend who would pick me up from the bridge and take me. On the way back, I would leave school, arrive, and leave my kid to the day care center, which was there at the school, and then I would go study. Twelve o'clock, 1 pm, I had to breastfeed her, so I had to go to the nursery, eat at the nursery, breastfeed her, and come back. And then I had to do a lot of homework and then I had to be there with my child. It was too much." Participant 26

Finally, half of the women we interviewed perceive that they are in prison directly or indirectly because of a man. This theme was repeated 76 times throughout the interviews. Some examples include:

"In fact, yes, I was with... because I went with my brother, the oldest male. But that time I was pregnant, and they told me that we should stop at the store for a coffee or dinner, it was already nighttime. And I said yes, but they were drinking. So, I was looking for cookies and all that, when I heard them yelling and hitting. And that's when I approached them, and they were already committing the crime (the crime she was accused of committing)." Participant 17

"Unfortunately, he was the person I was with, he was my client, and I am here because of that man. I am here for this aggravated kidnapping, I was with him when he collected a ransom, and he says that I took him from one place to another, when I had no knowledge of it. In the statements... now they have confirmed that I have a sentence of 25 years." Participant 20

"I see that every morning he would leave and come back. And he tells me 'I'm looking for jobs, while this season passes'. And I told him 'Ah, okay, perfect'. When I found out that he was involved in the sale and distribution of drugs, that's when I was arrested. Because during the whole time we were like that, I didn't see him bringing drugs to the house." Participant 24

"Yes, they're investigating me for his crime and then they found out that the van was registered under my name, supposedly a crime was committed in that vehicle and since he put it under my name... well that's why I'm here." Participant 2

Table 3.0: *Structural Gender Violence.*

Categories	Number of coding references	Percentage of participants who mentioned it at least once
Structural Gender Violence	372	94%
Gender Stereotypes	185	91%
Feminine Subjectivity/Gender Identity	120	70%
Gender Inequality	84	70%
I am in prison indirectly or directly because of a man	76	48%

I. Gender Violence within the Justice System

This research demonstrates how the justice system reproduces and generates structural violence in general, and gender violence in particular, rather than functioning as an institution designed to build positive peace through programs, reestablishing the social fabric, and effective reinsertion of offenders. The majority of our interviewees are aware of these factors; of whom 67% reported instances of violence against them as women in their detention processes, violence against them as women in legal practices, or perceived that the authorities treat them differently because they are women (this last category was mentioned by 55% of participants on 47 occasions). In addition, almost half of our interviewees referred to the lack of norms that guarantee women fundamental rights; 45% perceive that women in prison are a marginalized sector of society, and four out of ten perceive prison as a male model.

Here are some examples that illustrate this thematic subcategory:

"So, I told him 'Well, my name is x'. And (the officer) tells me 'Ahhh, well you're a whore and you were doing very well. How much did you earn? Well, if you are a whore, then give me a service. How much are you going to charge me?' And I responded: 'No sir! Don't say that to me!', 'Ah, now you act offended'. At that moment I was thinking about my children, about how I had left them. I said: 'I want to go now sir'. And he told me: 'You're not going to leave until you tell us the truth.' I responded: 'I'm telling you the truth', And he told me 'Well, you better tell the truth because otherwise we're going to find out by beating you'." Participant 20

"In fact, my children were already going to school and we were buying things for them in a supermarket, and when we left with their things and we were about to get into the truck, the cops arrived and surrounded us. They threw me into the ground, they took my children away in a van and they put me into a different car. When they took me, they beat me, they beat me a lot. I was badly beaten, I was raped. I was raped, I was beaten by the cops. They threatened me a lot, they said that they were going to make my children disappear if I didn't sign the paperwork, they wanted me to sign to label me as guilty. I signed all the statements that they gave

me, all the sheets that they gave to me, I signed them up, on the condition that they would take my children home safe and sound.” Participant 19

“I believe that in legal terms women are neglected, here in Mexico, their processes take many years; men always, somehow get their freedom. The last time here in this prison that a woman received a sentence, was about six months ago. In the four years and five months that I have been here, I have seen very few times in which women have received a sentence. More or less 80 or 100 guys were set free, and women are still stuck in here. There is inequality in legal matters, the process for women has been largely abandoned.” Participant 4

“I think that judges, I do not like labels in general. But the one assigned to my case, what he did was because of... I think it would be gender. He (the judge), did that a lot (gender discrimination). He said that because the one accused was my brother, 'it was going to be the same or even worse for me'. That's how he expressed it. I think when he said it, that hurt me more than the sentence he gave me.” Participant 17

“Unfortunately, when men commit crimes, they are less judged than women. The laws, unfortunately, although they say that they seek gender equality, it isn't true. It isn't true because there are men who can steal and they will give them less years, but a woman can steal to feed her children and they give her a high sentence, so there is no equity in that sense.” Participant 3

“Men, they have a hammock, we don't. They have more stuff. They have more ways to get stuff. I think they have workshops there, and we have nothing. We don't. Men have more priority than women. We are more marginalized.” Participant 23

Discussion

It is hard to emphasize the significance of what the existing evidence shows: both domestic violence and gender violence are highly correlated with violence associated with organized crime (IEP, 2019). This becomes even more apparent when we examine the Women's Peace and Security Index (GIWPS, 2021). Countries with the highest rates of armed or criminal violence also have the highest rates of violence against women. Conversely, the reduction of armed and domestic violence in those societies is directly influenced by measures aimed at enhancing women's well-being, status in society, inclusion, integration, rights, and opportunities (GIWPS, 2021). In light of this context, we provide a summary of the findings of the present study as follows:

First, among the inmate women we interviewed, there is not just one story but rather, there is a complex picture. In some instances, there are backgrounds that indicate close links to family and friends, as well as ongoing support networks. On the other hand, in some instances, the stories are characterized by much more dysfunctional circles, including the dissolution or absence of family ties or support networks that could have assisted them in coping with their current

circumstances. Gender violence, both visible and invisible, as well as structural violence, recurs throughout the interviews. This even applies to interviewees who claimed they come from good incomes or solid family backgrounds. In other words, the glue that links all these stories, is an ecosystem of structural gender violence.

Second, their incarceration situation is closely tied to this structural gender violence. This statement does not seek to reduce the agency of women who choose to commit crimes for a variety of reasons; rather, it is about rethinking one of our initial questions, which is echoed in a significant portion of the existing literature: "Why do women engage in crime? That question assumed that the participants in this study had committed a crime or crimes and were currently in jail for that reason. As a research team, it is obviously impossible to affirm or deny that the participants are guilty or innocent of the charges against them. This investigation reveals, however, that the majority of them believe they are innocent and spend a significant part of their conversation explaining it, detailing the factors that support their argument, and tend to vent their accumulated frustration against a system and a process that they consider as unfair and riddled with inconsistencies. Nevertheless, the fact that this theme is prevalent across twelve female prisons that are located in a several states of the nation and are so dissimilar from one another, raises the prospect of at least conceding the benefit of the doubt in terms of their innocence. Therefore, the findings of this study do not allow us to answer "What led these women to commit crimes?", but rather, "What factors led them to imprisonment?". And it is not the same.

Third, we could put it this way: While attempting to answer the question of whether or not structural gender violence was linked to crime, we discovered that the same structural violence may be closely linked to participants' perceived or actual innocence. It necessary to understand how the systemic conditions of structural gender violence allow, facilitate, and occasionally directly activate the circumstances that lead our participants to prison. This is subsequently reproduced in a seemingly inexhaustible circle both (structural gender-based violence and structural violence) during their trial and during their incarceration. What is notable is that their relationships with one or more men appear to be factors that either directly or indirectly contribute to the incarceration of women. Furthermore, gender stereotypes, gender-specific behaviors, and psychological gender violence, tend to persist during their legal process and their stay at the prison.

Fourth, structural gender violence is a widespread phenomenon that is not restricted to imprisonment or the prison setting. The interviews are, sadly, a reflection of lives dominated by violence. Nevertheless, if we assume that Mexico needs to build institutions and pillars that help restore the country's peace, then all the factors related to the violation of the rule of law, the commission of crimes, and violent crime, should be investigated and prosecuted by institutions that are working to heal, restore, and repair the social fabric and ties. Instead, the findings of our study appear to demonstrate that the legal system, in particular the one that prosecutes the women we interviewed, not only reproduces but also activates conditions that produce and reproduce direct and structural forms of gender violence.

Fifth, perhaps like a light in the middle of this complex tunnel, an interesting finding emerges in this investigation: Women who participate in workshops, courses, religious programs, paid work programs, or reinsertion projects are the notable exception to the disruption of peace caused by the penitentiary system. There, in this picture, lies a possibility for the experience in prison to

become an axis that does rebuild the social tissue and contributes to peacebuilding. Despite the fact that the findings of the present study are in line with the research previously carried out by this team (Meschoulam et al., 2020), it stands out that this pattern can be found in several other prisons than those we investigated in our previous research. This work, often carried out by civil society organizations, should not be minimized and should, in fact, be promoted as supported by the evidence provided by this new study.

Recommendations

This research points to the need to reconsider everything related to the areas mentioned above if there is any real interest in making Mexico a peaceful country with a gender perspective. This includes from studying in greater detail how women end up in situations where they are imprisoned, to the creation of mechanisms, policies, measurements, and institutions that contribute to preventing these circumstances, the design and restructuring of the system procedural process with a peacebuilding approach, and a prevailing gender perspective in it (instead of a machine that reproduces gender violence), and finally, the design or redesign of a penitentiary system that can contribute more effectively towards the repair and restoration of the social fabric.

In a nutshell, based on the aforementioned findings (which add to the vast existing literature on the subject), we recommend focusing on two areas: first, the system, probably the most significant; second, the setting in which women are tried for the crimes they are accused of, as well as the setting in which they enter and remain in prison. The following is a list of our recommendations:

1. Further investigation of these issues needs to be conducted by replicating studies such as the current one in larger areas of the country, in addition to quantitative studies based on findings such as those presented here, which may have greater external validity. In general, it is acknowledged that much work has already been done on this phenomenology. However, more research with a focus on peacebuilding is required in this area of expertise.
2. These results should be disseminated among actors in the public sector, private sector, and social sector. The many organizations and individuals already working in these fields can benefit from knowing the evidence presented here, in addition to the existing literature, to which findings from additional studies could be added. It can also contribute to the relative discussion of policies and actions aimed at promoting peace in nations like Mexico.
3. Projects to train individuals in the public, private, or social sectors who are in charge of making decisions implementing public policies, or designing specific strategies, in order to integrate a peacebuilding with a gender perspective approach into already existing programs or new ones, should be put in place. This encompasses an approximation that fully considers the system of structural and direct violence, that embraces the gender aspect in that structural and direct violence, and that incorporates positive peacebuilding from a gender perspective. Within this recommendation, we suggest a detailed

reevaluation of training programs or courses, paid work, social work, or reintegration projects that already exist in prisons for women. These will help understand which parts of such projects function as effective peacebuilding strategies through micro level, which of them need to be adjusted or modified, and which other types of programs that are not currently available could be added to the system

4. Beyond training, this investigation provides evidence that supports the implementation of public policies and actions for the prevention of structural and gender violence, as well as peacebuilding with a gender perspective based on concrete short-term, medium-term, and long-term measures at the national, state, and local levels. Obviously, this is too broad for the purposes of a limited study like this, but the ongoing efforts of governments at all levels, the private and social sector, academia, the media, and religious organizations, among many others, to systematically address the absence of peace in countries like Mexico require the inclusion of a gender perspective and cannot be overlooked.

5. In a more concrete sense, the present study provides evidence that demonstrates the necessity of enhancing peacebuilding programs among women in prison. This does not only refer to workshops, courses or paid work projects, rather, it includes programs that ensure their human dignity, the fairness of their legal processes, and the effective delivery of justice; that, among many related issues, take care of their material and emotional well-being, strengthen dialogue and conflict resolution skills, and work to restore the social fabric. As previously stated, a number of these tasks are already being carried out. However, a cross-cutting design that incorporates them under the umbrella of peacebuilding and fills the gaps that are found as part of that integral vision is required.

Conclusions

Peace is not limited to the absence of violence. Therefore, the discussion of gender-based violence needs to be integrated into a broader vision: peacebuilding with a gender perspective. That is to say, gender violence is not external to the system or the structures that facilitate, produce, and then reproduce it in a country with a high incidence of violence like Mexico. However, contemplating a peace system also necessitates an understanding of its active components, which include not only how to eradicate violence and structural gender violence but also how to generate and sustain the active components of positive peace. According to the Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP, 2021), these elements include "attitudes, institutions, and structures" that create and sustain the peace we yearn for.

This discussion cannot be separated from the imprisonment of women. The research we present depicts an ecosystem that goes right to the core of structural gender violence, from its origins to the circumstances that send women to jail, and as a result, reproduces the worst aspects of these structures right there.

There are long-term solutions and responsibilities that require our attention. However, if we do not lose sight of the horizon, there are also concrete actions, very specific and targeted measures, that this study supports and that could be implemented or incorporated into cross-cutting and

broader programs. These could be grouped into programs for women that guarantee their human dignity, their right to a fair trial, and efficient justice delivery; that, among other measures, prioritize reparation and the restoration of the social fabric, strengthen dialogue and conflict resolution skills, and ensure their emotional and material well-being. These actions are not destined to pull Mexico out of the labyrinth in which it unfortunately finds itself. However, if we assume that there is no peace without justice, and that justice implies incorporating a gender perspective in its delivery, prosecution, restoration and reintegration, then these are indispensable tasks for the most violent countries on the planet.

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A Study Investigating Depictions of Workplace Bullying in Hollywood Films

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Abstract

This research focused on the portrayal and depiction of workplace bullying from a sample of 100 popular Hollywood films over the past two decades. This study utilized Hymes's SPEAKING Model, a well-established ethnographic communication method (Hymes, 1974), because of its rich interpretive and descriptive nature and its focus on analyzing communication and interaction in terms of both verbal and nonverbal exchanges. This study applied the framework of Hymes's model and analyzed the mnemonic elements of SPEAKING: setting, participants, end, act sequence, key, instrumentalities, norms, and genre. The investigation was guided by the theoretical underpinnings of film theory, social construction theory, and symbolic interaction theory. The findings revealed theoretical frames that emerged and collectively these interpretive findings shed new light on understanding portrayals of workplace bullying in contemporary films. This research adds to the body of research on workplace bullying and calls attention to its expression in film.

A STUDY INVESTIGATING DEPICTIONS OF WORKPLACE BULLYING IN HOLLYWOOD FILMS

Alexia Georgakopoulos and Maria Georgo

Introduction

Bullying is the most prevalent form of violence in the workplace, has no boundaries, and damages healthy individuals and organizations (Chaplin, 2010, p. 438). The U.S. Workplace Bullying Institute's (WBI) national survey shows that 72% of American workers reported awareness of bullying in the workplace; 27% identified as victims, and 21% as witnesses (Namie, Christiansen, & Phillips, 2014). While most workplace bullying research has focused on psychological or social-psychological issues (Hutchinson & Jackson, 2014; Lewis & Rayner, 2003), this study used a new lens by exploring the questions, "can film help us make sense or meaning?" and "what do films convey through depictions of workplace bullying?" (Sutherland & Felty, 2013, p. 192).

There is a plethora of research connecting film, and the social world wherein movie scenes become reference material for social behavior. The role of movies in society is complex, and the debate continues regarding "when they mirror society and when they shape it" (McCullick, Belcher, Hardin, & Hardin, 2003, p. 5). Long after a film ends, it can continue to live on in thoughts, emotions, and interactions with others, becoming an integral part of the lived experience (Ross, S. 2014, pp. 9-11). This research aimed to take an in-depth look at depictions of workplace bullying in scenes of 100 popular Hollywood films released in the last two decades by exploring the ethnography of speaking within the context of workplace bullying. This study will begin with an overview of the literature on the powerful role of media and its link to workplace bullying. Next, it will move to the methodological design of this current research that utilizes ethnography. This section will be followed with the analyses of the data that includes the primary themes that emerged from the 100 films investigated in this study. Finally, a discussion will present the conclusions and implications of this study.

Literature Review

Historical Influence of Film

Movies have far-reaching influences on social life and continually prove to be powerful channels for disseminating ideas (Ross, S. 2014, p. 2). In 1923, a New York Times reporter described movies not as entertainment, but as a source of instruction and reflection influencing societal change in the US (Ross, S. 2014, p. 1). The Frankfurt School, created by international social theorists in 1923 (Routledge, 2011), argued that movies were producing "a mass society that undermines individuality, democracy, and the salutary aspects of high culture" (Kellner, 2004, p. 2). In response, the motion picture research council funded a study on the influence of movies on daily life (Keller, 2004, p. 2). These early studies were based on theories of propaganda and the belief that media had a direct influence on contributing to social problems (Keller, 2004, p. 3).

In the 1930s and 1940s, research shifted toward the influence of propaganda and concerns that

film was “promoting immorality, juvenile delinquency, and violence” (Kellner, 2004, p. 2). By the 1950s-1960s, going to the movies became a weekly tradition (Sutherland & Feltey, 2013, p. x). Films were bringing real-life issues to the screen (Ross, S. 2014, p. 4). The Vietnam War, women’s liberation, the sexual revolution, economic mobility, and the influx of international funding are examples of the social context from the 1960s throughout the 1980s (Ross, S. 2014, p. 6). Questions still persist on the influence of film.

Mediation Dependency Theory and Media Effect

Media has a formidable role in society as often people rely on it to form their attitudes and perceptions. Media Dependency Theory stresses that people likely depend on media, films, and television depictions to understand norms and behavior surrounding their attitudes and perceptions toward their environment. This dependency is heightened, especially when people do not have direct experiences in matters (Riffe & Varouhakis, 2008). For example, in the context of organizational life, people may depend on the media to inform them of what is acceptable to portray or accept within this setting. Workplace bullying may be illustrated as normative and even as provocative occurrences in the workplace in media depictions, so people will begin to normalize negative associations with real-world interactions and, in so become more complicit in accepting inappropriate norms because of these media depictions. These depictions are garnered from the different roles taken on by actors and media personalities that appear in media. Perhaps managers or superiors are commonly portrayed as aggressors with a thirst for unquestionable authority that manifests through regular verbal denigration, insidious harassment, and subtle or blatant sabotage. While these toxic behaviors are maladaptive for individuals, media dependency has significant impacts even in large-scale social disruption (Lowery, 2004). Today, the movement of Black Lives Matter that has ensued as a result of wrongful deaths to people of color who are tragically and brutally killed by police and the large-scale disruption and unrest between law enforcement and communities, gives society time to pause and reflect on how violence and tensions of this magnitude can be experienced. This movement has challenged people to reflect on what has gone array and media portrayals and depictions are part of the problem and root cause.

Media effect is interwoven with many influences, multifaceted, and sometimes convoluted. While in the early 1920s, media effect focused on what was referred to as the “hypodermic needle” effect; recent research argues that the audience is not passive (Ross, S. 2014, p. 7). Additionally, Katz (1959) points out that, “The selectivity approach emerged in the 1940s as a new paradigm that aimed to show that is more relevant to investigate what people do with media than what media do to people.” (p. 2) For example, it has often been found that people pay more attention to negative media content than to positive content, especially when it comes to news (Zillman et al. 2004). Considering and acknowledging media effects is integral to this study; recognizing the fundamental role of the characters, narratives, and context is imperative (Valkenburg et al. 2016). No longer can the media be unchallenged when topics such as harassment, bullying, and violence are investigated. For the purpose of this study, media dependency, and media effects are place squarely at the forefront of this study.

Role of Films